

CANASTA (CLASSIC)

Canasta is a partnership rummy-style game for four players (two teams of two). The game uses two standard 52-card decks plus 4 Jokers (108 cards total). Players build melds — groups of three or more cards of the same rank — aiming to form Canastas (melds of 7 or more cards). The first partnership to reach 5000 points wins.

Canasta originated in Uruguay in the 1940s and became internationally popular in the 1950s.

CARD VALUES

CARD	POINT VALUE
Joker	50
Ace or 2	20
K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8	10
7, 6, 5, 4	5
Black 3 (bonus/block card)	5
Red 3 (bonus card)	100 (or 200 if all four are held)

WILD CARDS

Wild cards: All four Jokers and all eight 2s (Deuces) are wild. Wild cards may substitute for any natural card in a meld.

Rules for wild cards in melds:

- ♦ A meld may contain at most 3 wild cards.
- ♦ A meld must always contain more natural cards than wild cards (e.g., 2 natural + 1 wild is fine; 2 natural + 2 wild is the maximum and only legal if there are 3 natural cards total).

SPECIAL CARDS

Red 3s: When drawn or dealt, a Red 3 must be placed face-up on the table immediately and replaced by drawing from the stock. Red 3s score a bonus at the end of the game (100 each; 800 for all four held by one partnership). Red 3s count for the partnership only if they have at least one canasta; otherwise they count against.

Black 3s: May not be melded during play (except as the final card in a hand, see Going Out). Black 3s may be discarded to freeze the pile for one turn against the next player (a one-turn block). Cannot be used as wild cards.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships. Partners sit opposite.
- ♦ Shuffle both decks together with all 4 Jokers for a 108-card deck.
- ♦ Deal 11 cards each (44 total). Place the remaining cards as the stock.
- ♦ Turn over the top card to begin the discard pile (the pack).
- ♦ If the initial upcard is a Joker, 2, or Red 3: bury it in the stock and turn another.
- ♦ If the initial upcard is a Black 3: the first player may not pick up the pack on their first turn; the Black 3 remains.

TAKING A TURN

Each turn consists of:

- 1 **Draw:** Take the top card from the stock OR take the entire discard pile (the pack) — subject to restrictions below.
- 2 **Meld:** Optionally create or extend melds on the table. Red 3s must be immediately placed.
- 3 **Discard:** Place one card face-up onto the discard pile. (Exception: do not discard when going out by melding all cards.)

TAKING THE PACK (DISCARD PILE)

A player may take the entire discard pile if:

- ♦ The top card of the pile is a natural card (not wild, not Black 3).
- ♦ The player holds at least two natural cards of the same rank as the top card and can immediately use them to meld with the top card.
- ♦ The partnership has already made its initial meld (see Initial Meld Requirement).

Frozen Pack: The discard pile is frozen when a wild card or Red 3 has been placed on it. To take a frozen pack, the player must hold two natural cards matching the top card (not just one plus a wild) and the rules above still apply. The pile unfreezes when picked up.

INITIAL MELD REQUIREMENT

A partnership's first meld(s) of the game must meet a minimum point value based on their current score:

PARTNERSHIP'S CURRENT SCORE	MINIMUM INITIAL MELD VALUE
Negative	15
0–1499	50
1500–2999	90
3000+	120

Once the initial meld is made, subsequent melds have no minimum.

MELDS

A meld is three or more cards of the same rank, placed face-up in front of the partnership. Valid ranks: 4 through Ace (2s and Jokers are wild; 3s are special). Natural melds contain no wild cards. Mixed melds contain 1–3 wild cards.

Partners share their melds: either partner may extend any of their partnership's melds on their turn.

CANASTAS

A **Canasta** is a complete meld of 7 or more cards. It is squared into a pile:

- ♦ **Natural Canasta (Clean):** 7 or more natural cards (no wild cards). Marked with a red card on top. Bonus: **500 points**.
- ♦ **Mixed Canasta (Dirty):** 7 or more cards including at least one wild card. Marked with a black card on top. Bonus: **300 points**.

A partnership must have at least one complete Canasta to go out.

GOING OUT

A player goes out by melding all remaining cards from their hand (including the final discard, or by melding all without discarding). The partnership must have at least one Canasta.

Asking permission: A player may ask their partner “Can I go out?” before going out; the partner must answer yes or no, and the decision is binding. This optional courtesy prevents surprise endings.

Going out concealed: If a player melds their entire hand in one turn without having previously melded any cards, they have gone out concealed. Bonus: **100 extra points** (in addition to the standard 100 go-out bonus).

SCORING (END OF HAND)

Going-out bonus: 100 points.

Each partnership scores:

- ♦ Value of all cards in completed melds and canastas

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- ♦ Canasta bonuses (500 per natural, 300 per mixed)

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- ♦ Red 3 bonuses (if at least one canasta held)

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- ♦ Going-out bonus (if applicable)

Minus:

- ♦ Value of cards remaining in hand (cards not melded)

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- ♦ Red 3 penalties (if no canasta held, Red 3s count against)

END OF GAME

The first partnership to accumulate 5000 or more points at the end of a hand wins.

ATTRIBUTION

Canasta. Originated in Montevideo, Uruguay, approximately 1939. Popularized internationally in the 1950s. Standard North American rules confirmed from Pagat.com and Hoyle's Rules of Games. Public domain rule set.